

## Case Study Two

### My Primary School is at Tate, Liverpool

*Building on an established relationship, a community nursery located a group of its pre-school children in the Tate Liverpool gallery for two weeks.*

*Both Tate and nursery staff were surprised at how quickly the children felt relaxed in their new surroundings and how well they behaved in the public spaces. The children started talking more and experimenting with their play.*

### **Key Facts**

#### Life Bank Kensington Children's centre and nursery

Kensington Children's Centre delivers quality childcare within the early years foundation stage for children aged six months to five years. The nursery provides a safe, secure and stimulating environment, with learning through play and challenging activities. The nursery offers a full and constantly evolving programme that includes regular visits to cultural organisations, including Tate Liverpool.

#### Tate Liverpool

Housed in a converted warehouse within the Albert Dock on Liverpool's waterfront, Tate Liverpool attracts around 600,000 visits a year. The gallery hosts a diverse exhibitions and events programme while displaying work from its national collection of British art from 1500 to the present day, as well as international modern art.

#### *Dates of project:*

29 February 2016 – 11 March 2016

#### *Number of pupils and age of pupils involved:*

24 pre-school nursery children (children aged 3-4) were based in the art gallery, with a maximum of 15 each day.

#### *Nursery team:*

Marie Harper, Acting Manager

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#### *Museum team:*

Katy McCall and Debbie Goldsmith, Learning Curators (job share)

Deborah Riding, Programme Manager for Children and Young People

Lindsey Fryer, Head of Learning

The Tate staff were assisted by independent artist teacher Denise Wright

*"We wanted them to have as much fun as possible and enjoy it, but feel safe and be comfortable and*

*feel like they own these spaces."*

Debbie Goldsmith, Tate Liverpool

*What happened during the project?*

Tate Liverpool's Early Years programme usually lasts two hours. So the opportunity for the nursery children to spend most of their day there during the two-week project allowed the nursery practitioners and Tate staff to adopt a more relaxing, open-ended dynamic.

Based in the gallery's Clore Learning Centre, the children were encouraged to explore the gallery's resources, moving from one space to another, to develop their interests. A specialist arts practitioner at the Tate created a large visual 'discovery tree' on the wall to map the children's interests, linking them to collections and other resources that children brought with them, such as toys, dolls and paintings. She added each activity to the tree so that by the end of the project it showed how each child's interests had been explored and developed.

During the play sessions children could choose from a wide variety of materials such as clay, sand, paints, string and straws and toys such as wooden blocks, toy animals, dolls and tea sets.

*"They actually wrapped the blocks into the tin foil and stood them all up and said it just looks like the art."*

Marie Harper, Kensington Children's Centre

*Which activities were particularly memorable?*

Trips outside the gallery - Tate staff accompanied the nursery group on a trip to the Museum of Liverpool, also based on the waterfront, and a trip on the ferry.

Art Gym - The children helped to set up a party at the gallery's Art Gym by making lanterns for the LED lights. They enjoyed dancing and mixing with other gallery visitors.

*"This project was much more exploratory and child-led [...than what?]. What they were interested in wasn't always what I would have picked out."*

Katy McCall, Tate Liverpool

*Benefits of the project:*

### **Tate Liverpool**

- The opportunity to observe very young children accessing the collection over an extended period
- Enthusiasm and support from people working around the gallery including security staff
- Endorsement from the highest levels of the Tate organisation which is investigating the possibility of future school residencies.

*"Our vision is really about co-design, co-creation and co-production. So My Primary School is at the Museum is just a fantastic way of testing that out."*

Lindsey Fryer, Tate Liverpool

### **Kensington Children's Centre**

- Nursery practitioners were able to test out ideas in a new environment with the support of experienced facilitators
- Transferring ideas from the gallery back in the nursery setting, including creating a mini-Tate
- Enthusiastic support from parents.

### **Children**

- Development of new friendships
- Increased confidence with speaking, especially in group discussions.
- Greater independence, for example, when choosing their own meals at the gallery café
- The variety of materials and activities allowed the children's imaginations to flourish.

*"We did have a wow-moment today. One of the children spoke for the first time to another child."*

Marie Harper, Kensington Children's Centre

*What were the main challenges?*

Resources at Tate Liverpool: finding the space to house a two-week project had an impact on access for other groups.

Staff: extra staff could have relieved the pressure on the adults supervising activities.